

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy Misuse risk: Medium

CORE FORMULA

Offer choice -> Remove pressure to agree -> Genuine — not performative

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before the next time you ask for something, explicitly give the person permission to say no or choose differently. Mean it.

BEST FOR

- Asking favours without creating obligation
- Giving feedback or advice without imposing
- Managing people without micromanaging
- Creating psychological safety in groups

PHRASE BANK

Autonomy Phrases · Giving genuine choice

- "No pressure — only if it works for you."
- "Feel free to say no — I mean that."
- "This is entirely your call."
- "I am not attached to you doing it my way."
- "You know your situation better than I do."
- "Say yes or no — both are genuinely fine."
- "I have a preference, but the decision is yours."
- "Take this or leave it — I will not be offended."

Remove Pressure · When someone seems reluctant

- "You do not have to decide now."
- "Take your time — this is not urgent."
- "There is no right answer here."
- "I am just offering it as one option."
- "Only do this if it genuinely makes sense for you."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Asking for something with implied obligation
Better: I know you are busy — only if you can.
Best: No pressure at all — say no if this does not work, I mean that.
2. Weak: Giving advice without invitation
Better: Can I share a thought on that?
Best: Ask first. If they say yes, give it once. If no, respect it.
3. Weak: Fake autonomy: 'It is up to you' when you clearly want a specific answer
Better: I have a preference but I want your input.
Best: Be honest about your preference AND genuinely release the decision.

DECISION TREE

If You want to give someone advice they did not ask for

Ask first. Give them the option to decline.

"Would it be useful to hear my view on that, or would you rather think it through yourself?"

If You are making a request and they seem reluctant

Name the opt-out explicitly.

"I want to make sure you know that no is a real option here."

If You offer autonomy and they keep asking for your preference

Give your honest preference once. Then return the decision to them.

"My preference is X — but this genuinely is your call."

If You use 'no pressure' but clearly want them to say yes

That is not autonomy — it is manipulation. Do not use it.

SCENARIOS

Asking a busy colleague for help

Make the opt-out genuine, not just polite. — "I am going to ask for a favour and I want to make sure you know you can say no: ..."

Giving feedback on someone's work unsolicited

Ask if they want it before giving it. — "Would it be helpful to hear what I noticed, or would you rather not?"

Directing a team member who has a strong view

Give your direction once. Then release it. — "My preference is X. That said, you know this better than I do — your call."

Conversation where the other person feels trapped

Name the opt-out explicitly to change the dynamic. — "I want to be clear: you can stop this conversation at any point and I will not be offended."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- In situations requiring a directive decision — releasing autonomy when a clear call is needed causes confusion.
- When the other person genuinely wants and needs your recommendation rather than options.
- In emergency or safety situations where autonomy is not operationally appropriate.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the hidden obligation

Notice one request you make today that has an implied obligation. Would you genuinely accept a no?

Day 2 — Genuine opt-out

In one request, explicitly name that no is a real option. Mean it.

Day 3 — Ask before advising

Before giving any advice today, ask if they want to hear it.

Day 4 — Accept the no

If someone uses the autonomy you gave them and says no, accept it without follow-up pressure.

Day 5 — Release the outcome

Give someone a real choice about something that matters and then genuinely let them choose.

Day 6 — Preference + release

Say your preference once clearly, then release the decision to them without attachment.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did people seem more relaxed? Did any 'no' sting? Did you follow through on the autonomy you offered?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I genuinely release the decision rather than perform it?
- Did I give a real opt-out — not a polite one?
- Did I ask before giving advice?
- Did I accept the outcome, including a no, without resentment?

- Did I avoid using 'no pressure' when I clearly wanted a yes?
- Did the other person seem more at ease after being given the choice?
- Did I state my preference clearly while still releasing the decision?